



April-May 1945

FALL OF GERMANY

After the failure of a final offensive in the hilly Ardennes between Belgium and France, Axis forces were in retreat on all fronts. Italy's Fascist leader Mussolini was killed on 28 April, by which time Soviet forces advancing westward were enveloping Berlin. To avoid capture, Hitler took his own life on 30 April, and Germany surrendered unconditionally to the Allies eight days later.

◀ Soldiers raise the Soviet flag over Berlin's Reichstag

12 April 1945 US President Roosevelt dies and is succeeded by Harry Truman

24 October 1945 The United Nations is established with the backing of 50 countries

1945

27 January 1945 Soviet troops liberate Auschwitz, the largest Nazi concentration camp complex

"We will accept nothing less than full victory. Good luck!"

*US GENERAL DWIGHT EISENHOWER
TO TROOPS EMBARKING ON THE
D-DAY LANDINGS, 1944*



△ Japanese surrender ceremony aboard USS Missouri

August 1945

DEFEAT OF JAPAN

Once the war in the West had ended, attention swung to the Pacific front, where Japan continued its rearguard action against Allied forces advancing up the Pacific island chain. To break the remaining resistance, the Allies resorted to massive air attacks on the Japanese heartland, culminating in the dropping of atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. The nation's formal surrender followed four weeks later.